among adults, unhealthy diets are the chief reason for such ailments among children and adolescents. Their junk food intake, in fact, is said to be at least three times that of adults.

The economic consequences are just as alarming. The ICMR estimates that 56.4 per cent of India's total disease burden—measured in financial costs, hospitalisation expenses and lost productivity due to illness, including sick leave from school and work—is linked to the rising consumption of junk food. However, despite the severe health risks, our regulations remain woefully short of prioritising public health over profits for industry.

According to the 2024 Global Food Policy report by the International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI), at least 38 per cent of Indians consumed unhealthy foods while 22 per cent didn't eat any fruits or vegetables. Several factors have driven the shift away from traditional diets. "Food choices are complex, influenced by family dynamics, with women majorly responsible for putting food on the table, socio-economic status, convenience, accessibility, affordability and the food options available in the market," explains Purnima Menon, senior director, food and nutrition policy, IFPRI. Accessibility and affordability make junk food consumption an overwhelming concern across income strata. "In fact," as Dr Hemalatha R., well-known nutritionist and director of ICMR's National Institute of Nutrition, points out, "it is a much bigger concern for poor families, who often lack access to the right knowledge and end up spending their limited resources on ultra-processed food instead of nutritious options."

TRICKING THE BRAIN

Another reason that encourages overconsumption of junk food is its hyperpalatable nature, which manufacturers achieve by leveraging science. Does the vanilla ice cream you love contain natural vanilla? Not really. It's actually made with lab-engineered chemicals from flavour makers. "The science of using flavour molecules—seen in packaged foods as 'added flavours'—has grown exponentially over the past few decades," says Prof. Ganesh Bagler at IIIT (Indraprastha Institute of Information Technology), Delhi, a researcher in the field of computational gastronomy. "These artificial flavours, far cheaper than natural products, trick the brain into thinking they are eating something nutritious, like a mango drink with real mangoes when in reality, it's just a soda with an artificial mango flavour." Hence, junk food addiction isn't just about habit or preference—it involves complex biochemical reactions in the brain and body. High levels of sugar, fat and refined flour further enhance its addictive nature. These foods are addictive because excessive consumption alters the gut microbiome, affecting several hormonal pathways in the body, says Dr Piyush Ranjan, vice-chairperson of the Institute of Liver Gastroenterology at Delhi-based Sir Ganga Ram Hospital.

THE JUNK TAKEOVER

Labelled as HFSS (high in fat, salt, and sugar) foods, junk food has become a pervasive part of daily life—yet its impact is alarmingly harmful

The Instant Gratification Boom

A culture of convenience has led to a surge in the consumption of foods loaded with preservatives and sweeteners over the past four years



Source: Worldpanel's monthly purchase track of about 85,000 households representative of India

"The increased consumption of ultra-processed foods, which are high in calories but poor in nutrients, is leading to an obesity epidemic, which in turn becomes the causal pathway to several other metabolic disorders"

DR R.M. ANJANA
MD, Dr Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre, Chennai

For instance, an excessive presence of sugar or fructose increases blood sugar levels, leading to the release of dopamine, a pleasure neurotransmitter. When dopamine floods the brain's reward centre, it creates a sense of pleasure. Over time, this pleasurable sensation turns into a habit and, eventually, an addiction. That's why one needs more junk food to experience the same level of pleasure. This process